The Xai-Xai Community and the Gcwihaba Cave

The Xai-Xai village is situated in Western Ngamiland 10 km east of the Namibian border. This is the nearest village to the caves. The community of Xai-Xai use the caves to generate income through tourism activities. This is done without compromising the authenticity of the caves. The activities are run by the Xai-Xai Tlhabololo Trust on behalf of the community.

Planning Your Visit

Make sure you have the following items with you:

- Torch and extra batteries
- Safety helmets
- Masks and hiking shoes.

Some Rules

Gcwihaba is a national monument administered by the Botswana National Museum and protected by the revised Monuments and Relics Act (2001). Adherence to some basic guidelines will make your visit worthwhile and ensure the continued protection of a part of Botswana's unique heritage.

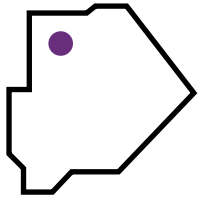
- Report to the gatehouse for assistance.
- Take litter away with you or leave it in trash can available.
- Do not touch or interfere with cave formations.
- Firearms and pets are not allowed.
- Do not smoke, drink or eat within the caves. Only water is allowed.

PLEASE NOTE:

Researchers and commercial photographers, contact the Botswana National Museum for permission.







Designation: Natural
Area: approx. 3km²
Adoption priorities:
visitor interpretation centre, field assistants, signage, trails

For further information, contact:
The Archaeology Division, Botswana National Museum
Private Bag 00114 Gaborone, Botswana
Phone: +267 3974616 Fax: +267 3911186 / 3902797

GCWIHABA
caves

BOTSWANA national museum

ADOPT A MONUMENT
GIVING LIFE TO BOTSWANA'S HERITAGE SITES

GC201511

Natural Heritage Site

GCWIHABA CAVES

About the Caves

Gcwihaba caves are found in the North West of Botswana in the Ngamiland District west of the Okavango Delta. They are located along the coordinates: S20 01. 456 E 02121. 258 in the community controlled hunting area NG4. The caves are also known as Drotsky's caves and were also publicized as such because they were shown to Martinus Drotsky, a Gantsi famer in June 1934 by local residents.

The caverns were formed in the dolomite marble of the Precambrian Damara age when wetter conditions and acidulated water flowing underground dissolved the rocks and later a river forming nearby lowered the water table emptying them. Subsequently, a variety of cave formations including fascinating stalactites and stalagmites formed as early as 3-2 million years ago. Minor seasonal precipitations still occury today. The caverns also have to bats, rats and bugs.

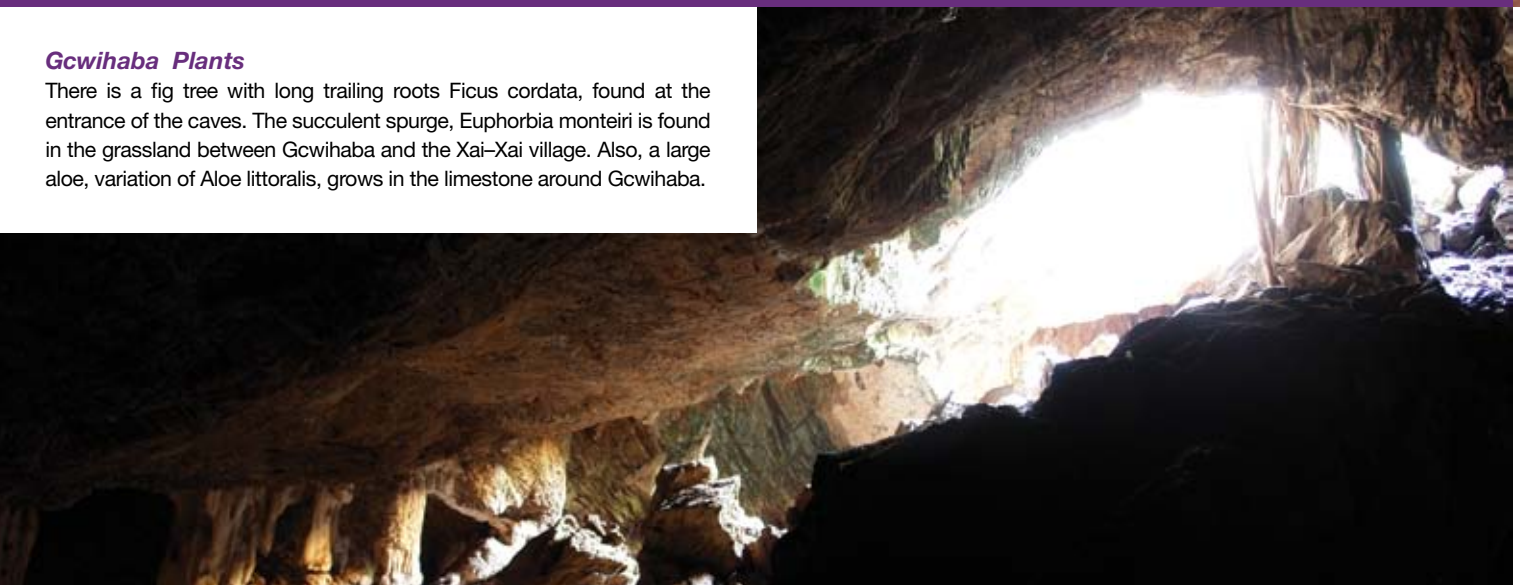






Gcwihaba Plants

There is a fig tree with long trailing roots Ficus cordata, found at the entrance of the caves. The succulent spurge, Euphorbia monteiri is found in the grassland between Gcwihaba and the Xai–Xai village. Also, a large aloe, variation of Aloe littoralis, grows in the limestone around Gcwihaba.



Access

There are currently two routes accessible by four wheeled drive vehicles only.

Nokaneng Route

The road goes 122 kilometres west from Nokaneng (along Maun -Shakawe tarred road) to Xangwa village. From Xangwa, the road turns south for 48 kilometres to the village of Xai-Xai. The caves are a further 36 kilometres south east of Xai-Xai village. This is a six hour drive.

Tsau Route

About nine kilometres north west of the village of Tsau (along the Maun-Shakawe tarred road), the road travels west for 144 kilometres to the cave. This is approximately a 4 ½ hours drive.
Of the two routes, the Nokaneng route is the most preferred because it is busier and less remote.